General Availability of FHL Color FLEX 5.0:4 – Obsolete Computer Systems

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The FLEX single-user Operating System initially released by TechnicalSystem Consultants in 1978 was the most widely adopted operating system forMotorola 6800 and 6809 systems. FLEX has a large catalog of applicationsincluding: word processors, spreadsheets, general business applications,and many editors, assemblers, tools, and programming languages. Frank HoggLaboratory brought FLEX to the Color computer in 1982, almost a full yearbefore Microware's OS-9 came to the CoCo in 1983. FLEX was largelyforgotten in favor of the more powerful and flexible OS-9. While notcompletely lost in the modern age the existing versions available in thearchives were not runnable. Today Obsolete Computer Systems is happy toannounce the General Availability of the newly restored Color Computer FLEX5.0:4 from Frank Hogg Laboratory. These have been imaged from physicaldisks in the Obsolete Comptuer Systems (MikeyN6IL) collection and restoredto formats which are usable for CoCo users in the 21st century, including:XRoar emulator, on a real CoCo with a CoCo SDC or Floppy Drive, or evenright in your web browser!

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0. QuickStart

a. Run a FLEX Demo Right in your Web Browser! Go to:

http://flex.ocs.net

And click on the first link “Live Demo”

b. Download the zip file from the Internet Archive:

https://archive.org/details/color-flex-5.0.4-frank-hogg-laboratory

c. Using with XRoar

Use XRoar 1.4 or later. Set up to run as a CoCo and use the DMK formatdisk images. To start FLEX type:

```
RUN "FLEX
```

d. Using with a CoCo SDC

Copy the SDF disk iamges to your SD Card. Use SDX or DRIVE commands toattach the disk images. To start FLEX type:

```
RUN "FLEX
```

e. Using with physical disks

Use a GreaseWeazle, FluxEngine or similar to write the SCP Flux images tomake exact copies of the disks. Both 5.25″ and Double-Density(720k) 3.5″disks may be used. To start FLEX type:

```
RUN "FLEX
```

f. Additional FLEX Software available:

https://archive.org/details/color-utilities-flex-frank-hogg-laboratory
https://archive.org/details/ed-editor-flex-frank-hogg-laboratory
https://archive.org/details/extended-6809-basic-flex-technical-systems-consultants

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1. Background

While there have been disk images for FLEX floating around the interwebsfor some time, if you tried to use these images they simply would not work.The reason why is FLEX has unique disk formatting with a Single-Density(FM)track 0 containing 10-sectors and the rest of the tracks areDouble-Density(MFM) containing 18-sectors. Most emulators by default donot expect this. They default to having all of the sectors of the diskuniformly formatted with the same number of sectors on every track. WhenFLEX tries to access Track 0 it fails because of this assumption.

To restore these disk images, I simply had to correct the formatting issuesand provide the disk images in useful formats which maintain the properformatting.

I have gone over the restoration process in detail in a YouTube Video:

[Watch on YouTube]()

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2. FLEXing the Color Computer YouTube Series

For more information please see one of my YouTube videos:

PlayList:https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLKZPh42EUcynotoZhJ6Z7dN0DUDfs2OaU

MikeyN6IL's VLOG $0D: FLEXing the CoCo Ep.1: History::https://youtu.be/wxjyv4LzXe8

MikeyN6IL's VLOG $0E: FLEXing the CoCo Ep.2: Editing and Assemblinghttps://youtu.be/XD7kG-iluwE

MikeyN6IL's VLOG $0F: FLEXing the CoCo Ep.3: Restorationhttps://youtu.be/Uj2AK9lkVe0

MikeyN6IL's VLOG $10: FLEXing the CoCo Ep 4: Artifactshttps://youtu.be/E30y-yEvGDE

MikeyN6IL's VLOG $11: FLEXing the CoCo Ep 5: Releasehttps://youtu.be/uBkrlUfA_5Q

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3. Frank Hogg Labs Color FLEX 5.0:4

https://archive.org/details/color-utilities-flex-frank-hogg-laboratory

This package contains FHL Color FLEX 5.0:4 copied from a physicalfloppy disk found in MikeyN6IL's Collection.

The same disk image is provided in 3 different formats: SCP, DMK, and SDF

Note that DSK or IMA format sector images are not provided because they arenot useful on a CoCo. HxCFlopyEmulator Software or Mikey's dmk tool can beused to create them.

Package Contents::

fhl_flex_5_0_4.scpThe SCP image was made from a physical disk using a GreaseWeazle

fhl_flex_5_0_4.DMKDMK conversion of above. This is usable in XRoar and Emulators.

fhl_flex_5_0_4.SDFSDF conversion of above for the CoCoSDC

Also in this package:::

fhl_flex_5_0_4.pngImage of the original floppy disk

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4. Frank Hogg Labs Color Utilities

https://archive.org/details/color-utilities-flex-frank-hogg-laboratory

This package contains FHL Color Utilities copied from a physical floppydisk found in MikeyN6IL's Collection.

The same disk image is provided in 3 different formats: SCP, DMK, and SDF

Note that DSK or IMA format sector images are not provided because they arenot useful on a CoCo. HxCFlopyEmulator Software or Mikey's dmk tool can beused to create them.

Package Contents::

fhl_color_utilities.scpThe SCP image was made from a physical disk using a GreaseWeazle

fhl_color_utilities.DMKDMK conversion of above. This is usable in XRoar and Emulators.

fhl_color_utilities.SDFSDF conversion of above for the CoCoSDC

Also in this package:::

fhl_color_utilities.pngImage of the original floppy disk

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5. Frank Hogg Labs “ED” Editor

https://archive.org/details/ed-editor-flex-frank-hogg-laboratory

This package contains FHL “ED” Editor copied from a physical floppy diskfound in MikeyN6IL’s Collection.

The same disk image is provided in 3 different formats: SCP, DMK, and SDF

Note that DSK or IMA format sector images are not provided because they arenot useful on a CoCo. HxCFlopyEmulator Software or Mikey’s dmk tool can beused to create them.

Package Contents::

fhl_ed.scpThe SCP image was made from a physical disk using a GreaseWeazle

fhl_ed.DMKDMK conversion of above. This is usable in XRoar and Emulators.

fhl_ed.SDFSDF conversion of above for the CoCoSDC

Also in this package:::

fhl_ed.pngImage of the original floppy disk

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6. Technical Systems Consultants Extended BASIC

https://archive.org/details/extended-6809-basic-flex-technical-systems-consultants

This package contains TSC Extended BASIC copied from a physicalfloppy disk found in MikeyN6IL’s Collection.

The same disk image is provided in 3 different formats: SCP, DMK, and SDF

Note that DSK or IMA format sector images are not provided because they arenot useful on a CoCo. HxCFlopyEmulator Software or Mikey’s dmk tool can beused to create them.

Package Contents::

tsc_extended_basic.scpThe SCP image was made from a physical disk using a GreaseWeazle

tsc_extended_basic.DMKDMK conversion of above. This is usable in XRoar and Emulators.

tsc_extended_basic.SDFSDF conversion of above for the CoCoSDC

Also in this package:::

tsc_extended_basic.pngImage of the original floppy disk